

become addicted. We don't truly understand the cause of addiction and whether that should be attributed more to nature or to nurture. What we do understand, however, is the key role addiction plays with the brain.

A Harvard Mental Health Letter published in July 2011 as 'How addiction hijacks the brain' put it best and because addiction is such an important, sensitive and highly nuanced subject, I want to quote part of that letter here.

Addiction exerts a long and powerful influence on the brain that manifests in three distinct ways: craving for the object of addiction, loss of control over its use, and continuing involvement with it despite adverse consequences.

According to the current theory about addiction, dopamine interacts with another neurotransmitter, glutamate, to take over the brain's system of reward-related learning. This system has an important role in sustaining life because it links activities needed for human survival (such as eating and sex) with pleasure and reward. The reward circuit in the brain includes areas involved with motivation and memory as well as with pleasure. Addictive substances and behaviors stimulate the same circuit—and then overload it. Repeated exposure to an addictive substance or behavior causes nerve cells in the nucleus accumbens and the prefrontal cortex (the area of the brain involved in planning and executing tasks) to communicate in a way that couples liking something with wanting it, in turn driving us to go after it. That is, this process motivates us to take action to seek out the source of pleasure.

I wanted to spell this out clearly to recognise that addiction is real and can be studied through what is happening in our bodies and our behaviour. However, it's also something that we can recover from—but only if we choose to.

There is so much talk about spenders and savers in the media. There are lighthearted books written about shopaholics and even a movie, but very little is written about the serious side of financial compulsion and addiction. Today gamblers and addictive shoppers can be advertised to